An Explanatory Commentary on the First Chapter of the Great King of Tantras Called the Noble Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara

Āryaḍākinīvajrapañjaramahātantrarājakalpamukhabandha · Toh 1195 · Derge Tengyur

འཕགས་པ་མཁའ་འགྲོ་རྡོ་རྗེ་གུར་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་རྒྱུད་kyi་རྒྱལ་པོ་ཆེན་པོའི་བརྟག་པ་དང་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོའི་བཤད་སྦྱར་ས།

This text is An Explanatory Commentary on the First Chapter of the Great King of Tantras Called the Noble Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara, known in Sanskrit as the Āryaḍākinīvajrapañjaramahātantrarājakalpamukhabandha and in Tibetan as 'Phags pa mkha' 'gro ma rdo rje gur zhes bya ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po chen po'i brtag pa dang po'i rgyal po'i bshad sbyar. Composed by the Indian master Kṛṣṇa, also called Kṛṣṇapāda, it is a concise commentary on the opening chapter of the Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara, the Vajra Tent of the Ḍākinīs, an explanatory tantra of the Hevajra cycle. Working through the root text phrase by phrase, it explains how the deity abides as the ultimate nature of all things while pervading everything conventionally, the purity of the aggregates, elements and sense sources, selflessness as understood in Yogācāra and Madhyamaka terms, the generation of the deity from moon and sun discs of letters, the arrangement of the goddesses and the alternative forms of the maṇḍalas of Heruka, Nairātmyā and the Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara, the stages of approach and accomplishment, the six-limbed yoga, and the secret empowerment. It is Toh 1195 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of tantra commentaries, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Gayādhara and the Tibetan translator Shākya Yeshé.

In the language of India: ārya ḍākinī vajrapañjar mahātantrarāja klpa nāma mukhabandha
In the language of Tibet: An Explanatory Commentary on the King of the First Chapter of the Great King of Tantras called the Noble Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara

Homage to glorious Vajraḍāka.

I, Kṛṣṇa, far removed from wisdom,
Bow to the one who has fully embraced compassion,
Who is called Vajrasattva,
That guide and protector;
And having bowed at the feet of the master,
The striving lord of supreme vigor,

I shall explain a little of the Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara
For the sake of recollection.

Through the passage beginning "In space," it is taught that, in ultimate terms, he abides as the ultimate nature of all things, and that, examined in conventional terms, he abides in everything. Because the Teacher, the Blessed One, makes the principle to be accomplished in the Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara pervade all beings, I shall first make this clear. The compiler, Vajragarbha, stated it in the words "Hevajra abides pervading the moving and the unmoving."

Now, because it is explained within the text, I shall first explain the connection between the five great elements and the generation stage, and the lord of their habitual tendencies. Among these, because space is not evident, I shall speak of space itself and the rest. "In space" means in what is free of obstruction. "In the inert" means in what is hard by nature, and in earth. "In the clear" means in liquid, and in water. "In what has no room" means in fire, because it brings about becoming and allows no room at all. "In what opens" means in the eye, in objects, and in wind. These very ones and the rest also become Pukkasī and the others:

Or else, earth is declared to be Pukkasī;
The water element is called Śavarī;
Heat should be known as Caṇḍālī;
Wind is renowned as Ḍombinī.

"Blissful space" refers to constantly holding to the yoga of the deity; and, as the abode of all these, he taught the instruction on the sattva of the actual completion stage. "In the manifold" means in space, because he pervades all beings by way of emptiness. "In the four vajras" refers to what is called the manifold discipline, to all the abodes of Vajrasattva, and to the maṇḍala of Mahendra. "In the dwelling" refers to its celestial palace and to the water maṇḍala. "In the realm of sentient beings": by this is meant the fire maṇḍala above that. "In the pleasing" means what captivates the mind through the mind. In the abode of these and in the wind maṇḍala, he abides in that proliferation of the great elements. "In the great sentient being" refers to the world of living beings. "In the vessel" speaks of his proliferation also in the dwelling places of sentient beings, the earth, and so on. The passage beginning "In the earth" refers to his appearing as bliss beneath the earth, in

the human world, and in the heavens. This teaches that he abides pervading all worlds. What is taught with "In the mind" is that he abides in these as the goddesses. Then Khecarī (she who moves in the sky) is the vajra of mind; in the vajra of speech is Bhūcarī (she who moves on the earth); and in the body is Pātālavāsinī (she who dwells below). They arise from the seed syllables oṃ āḥ hūṃ. The activities of body and the rest are also taught. "In one, in two" refers to the consciousness of the apprehended and the apprehender. "In the bliss of space" refers to the nature of being and nonbeing, and that is called "in space":

This very gnosis is great;
It abides in every body,
In the mode of the dual and the nondual,
The lord of being and nonbeing.

I shall speak of these six families as purified. "In six" means: further, the six families should be known by these designations:

Attachment, aversion, and delusion,
Samaya, sentient being, and jewel:
Fully accomplishing the liberation desired,
These are declared to be the six families.

If one searches in terms of the substances of the Vaibhāṣikas and the Sautrāntikas, it should be firmly established that whatever beings there are, he pervades them. "Five" refers to these five aggregates becoming deities. Further:

In the form aggregate is Vajrā;
Feeling is declared to be Gaurī;
Perception is Vāriyoginī;
Formations, Vajraḍākinī;
In the mode of the consciousness aggregate
Abides Nairātmyayoginī (the Yoginī of Selflessness).

Aversion and the rest, five in all, are also taught. Their purification, too, is their becoming goddesses, as follows:

What is called aversion is declared to be Vajrā;
Attachment is Vāriyoginī;
Jealousy is Vajraḍākinī;
Avarice is Guptagaurī;

Delusion likewise is declared to be Vajrā.
This is the purifying of aversion and the rest.

As for the proliferation of the form aggregate, one should understand it as abiding in the twelve sense sources. "In twice six" means that these are to be distinguished as goddesses, as follows:

In the eyes, set Mohavajrā (Vajrā of Delusion);
Dveṣavajrā (Vajrā of Aversion) in the ears;
In the nose, Mātsaryavajrā (Vajrā of Avarice);
In the mouth, Rāgavajrā (Vajrā of Attachment);
In touch, Īrṣyāvajrā (Vajrā of Jealousy);
In the mind, one should meditate on Nairātmyā.
In form, Gaurī is rightly declared;
In sound, Caurī is renowned;
In the domain of smell, Vetālī;
In taste, Ghasmarī is renowned;
In touch, Bhūcarī is declared;
In the sphere of phenomena, Khecarī.

In the Vaibhāṣika system, too, the sense sources are sense sources whose intrinsic nature is the elements and what consists of the elements. So, investigating in line with that system, it is precisely through these, present in beings, that he is said to abide everywhere, together with the deities. In the Sautrāntika system, what is called "the elements themselves transformed" refers to form, the tangible, and so on. "In four" means in form, taste, smell, and the tangible. In these very ones, too, he is taught to abide as the intrinsic nature of the aggregates, the elements, the sense sources, the desire realm, and so on. "In beings" means "also in four." Here, the desire realm, the form realm, the formless realm, the supreme of the world, and the four beginning with Vajrasattva are in the three kinds of beings. Concerning the proliferation of the gnosis of form and so on, it is said, "Or one short of twenty." This means that what is called "the eighteen elements, the intrinsic nature unborn from the very beginning," is "one short of twenty." These are the sense faculties, the objects themselves, and the consciousnesses of the sense faculties.

So that the yoginīs may understand,
The elements are taught as eighteen.
By intrinsic nature unborn from the very beginning,

Not true, and likewise not false,
All is like the moon in water.
Know this, as the yoginīs desire:
The eighteen elements are completely pure.

The aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources are to be known as completely pure. Being unborn by intrinsic nature is the single purity, and that very purity purifies all the others, however many there may be.

If one asks what that complete purity is like: in order to present it specifically, it is put in brief in the passage beginning "In the three realms." Here it is said that in the desire realm, in great delight, couples embrace, hold hands, laugh, and gaze; and it is said that the very intentions of sentient beings, and father, son, and mother goddess (mātṛkā), abide. The passage beginning "Father and" is said with reference to the form realm. "In external objects" means that the nature of sensual enjoyment has been abandoned. "In the inner," too, refers to mere gnosis in the formless realm. "In all the consorts" refers to the supreme of the world and the retinue of goddesses. "In the Dharma" refers to its collection. As for "in all actions," it is not categorically asserted here that its ordinary activities and the like are established by valid cognition, and their intrinsic nature, too, is to be stated in those terms.

"In selflessness": the absence of self in the person is what is meant by selflessness. Here are taught the meditation on selflessness as well, namely that within saṃsāra there are only fruits and productive causes, and the state of abiding as an arhat. "In the fruit" is said because the fruit of stream-entry and the others are accomplished as fruits. "Cause" is said because they arise from practicing the meditation on selflessness and the like. The productive cause alone is not the cause, because the action too must be understood. In the passage beginning "In the cause," the word "pervades" is the name of the action.

Because these two, individually, have the nature of what is to be accomplished and of accomplishing, accomplishment is taught in the words "In the vajra of what is to be accomplished and the means of accomplishment." That is, the fruit of stream-entry and the others are what is to be accomplished, because they arise from the meditation on selflessness. There is also the means of accomplishment, because they are to be known through meditating on selflessness. The meditation on selflessness and the like are also cause and

what is to be accomplished, for the sake of knowing the fruit of stream-entry and the others. It is the means of accomplishment because it is the very agent of the fruit of stream-entry and the others.

According to the Yogācāra system as well, the abiding of beings is taught. "Likewise" means that fruit and cause, too, are to be viewed in this way. "All-base consciousness" refers to that in which self, sentient beings, and objects have subsided and the habitual tendencies have been abandoned. "In the dharmadhātu" refers to the arising of such things as grasping at a self of phenomena, and to their cause, the afflicted mind. "Not arisen" means that here, because the nature is indivisible, separate arising is excluded.

The practice of the selflessnesses, the state of an arhat within saṃsāra by way of consciousness as mere cause and fruit, is taught. The passage beginning "Fruit" teaches the connection between fruit and cause. The passage beginning "In the action" is said because effects and actions, such as smoke, do not exist without fire and the like. Because what is to be accomplished and the logical reason are to be understood through fire and smoke, both of these, too, are means of accomplishment. That is, smoke and the like are to be understood as means of accomplishment. Through seeing unerringly with one's own understanding that the external and other means of accomplishment, and the agent, are without parts, one should regard the apprehended and the apprehender as though they were divisions within correct awareness. These are merely words.

Beings and so on are taught. "In sentient beings" reflects the intent of such statements as "the all-base consciousness of the container world is one from another"; this is what is meant by it here. There, "the element of space" is the sattva element.

The distinguishing point of "the self of those other than that" is taught. "Selflessness and self" means that, according to the Madhyamaka system, whatever beings there may be are taught as its abode. "Non-being and" is said from the standpoint of the ultimate. "Not non-being" is said because of the way entities exist conventionally.

The distinctive features of the abode that is attained are taught. The passage beginning "In Sukhāvatī" means practicing yoga as if in the state of being immersed within saṃsāra. "Born of a" refers to the moon disc of the letters beginning with a. "In the one free of fault" refers to the letters beginning with ka, the sun disc. "Free of dust" refers to the vajra. "Destroyer of evil" refers to

vajra pride. "In the glorious, waveless nature" states that the deity abides in the form of Samantabhadra.

The proliferation of the deities is taught in the passage beginning "In the secret." There, "secret" means that this maṇḍala of Heruka, whose intrinsic nature is the completely pure dharmadhātu, is to be accomplished. "Supreme" is explained thus: the discriminating gnosis, that of Padmanarteśvara. "Delighted" is the gnosis of equality itself, and refers to Vajrasūrya. "Self of all" has the characteristic of the perfection of diligence. "The all-pervading Buddha" is that of Paramāśva. "Sattva" refers to earnest activity. "Lord of the gods" is the activity of an exceptional person. "Lord of the gods" teaches at length, from the word "person," what is called "secret."

The passage beginning "Five" again follows the order of the brief presentation, and teaches in detail the supreme sequence of deities in the maṇḍala of Heruka. In the passage beginning "Gaurī," in a square maṇḍala with a single tier, the four goddesses beginning with her guard the eastern gate and the others. Pukkasī and the rest are properly stationed in the intermediate directions, beginning with that of Īśāna, the northeast. This is the maṇḍala made up of nine. In this way, the Dry One and the rest are the gatekeeper goddesses. Puṣpā and the rest are in the corner sections. Likewise, the sun and the rest are at the gates.

Lāsyā, Mālā, and likewise Nṛtyā and Gītā are in the intermediate directions. Likewise, the lotus and the rest dwell at the gates. Vaṃśā, Vīṇā, Murajā, and Mukundā are to be understood as being in the intermediate directions. Vajra Bolt and the rest dwell at the gates. Locanā, Māmakī, Pāṇḍaravāsinī, and Tārā are in the intermediate directions.

As for "Where it is explained":
The Buddha's maṇḍala is a circle;
That of the Vajra Bearer is like a half-moon;
That of Vajradharma resembles a lotus;
That of the Sun is like a wish-fulfilling jewel;
And that of the one called Paramāśva
Is the triangle of all the sugatas.

Then, with the heart tiers of those in view, these too come to be arranged in two tiers.

In "In order to host beings with the inexhaustible," "inexhaustible" means liberation, which is never exhausted. "In order to host" means to attend to

them as guests. It is with reverence toward beings, in order to feed them with that which is inexhaustible.

"Empty" means that everything that is presented, even conventionally, is devoid of the characteristics of a real entity. "Method is not emptiness" means that, from the standpoint of the yoga of generating the body, it is false even conventionally. "In order to reverse thoughts of clinging to self": the intent is that, in order to cut off holding the self as supreme, grasping at a person, grasping at phenomena, and grasping at the intrinsic nature of phenomena, everything is valid conventionally.

Then, as is also explained right here, the passage beginning "Focusing on the pride of a buddha, meditating on the luminous dharmadhātu" teaches the distinctive features of offering.

Again, in the passage beginning "Vajra," "the pure place" refers to the great wheel (cakra). "The great place" refers to the wheel of enjoyment. "Completely filled by all the buddhas" refers to the wheel of Dharma. "Pervaded throughout by vajra jewels" refers to the wheel of emanation. "The city of benefit" refers to the wheel of the body, that is, to the physical body. This teaches in detail the nature of what has arisen in that way from speech and mind.

"Vajra chain" refers to the great illusion of all the buddhas, inner and outer, that is, to outer and inner approach. Likewise, the passage beginning "One should bind with the vajra fetter" is near accomplishment. "One will soar to Tuṣita" is accomplishment. "Of the buddhas" is great accomplishment. In this way the attainment of the fruit is also taught.

"Attains what is desired": here too it is taught that the bodhisattvas abide in the unsurpassed. The passage beginning "Maitreya" teaches accomplishing by force through Aṅkuśī and the rest. "Five hundred thousand children": the full awakening of Vajragarbha and so forth are taught together with a special dance by thirty thousand.

The passage beginning "Source of phenomena" is the commitment (samaya) for accomplishing the vajra. The lotus is its bhag, and that is the woman herself. With the song that is the method for becoming liberated, the vajra itself is aroused. "At the end, the drum, lāsye, and so on" means that at the end there is play with the vajra drum and the like.

"The seven are to be made completely pure" means:
The buddha abode, perfect in every aspect,

Meditation on the five aspects,
The nature of Samantabhadra,
Accomplishing one's own special deity,
The arrangement of the maṇḍalas,
And offering, praise, nectar, and so on:
These are to be meditated on in sequence.
Set them out as the six limbs of yoga.

The stage of self-blessing is also the sixth. Moreover, when this is explained as subtle yoga, another stage of self-blessing is taught. The passage beginning "Moving" refers to drawing out; it is taught as a special form of the upward training.

The passage beginning "Immediately" concerns those called Bhūcarī and the rest. How does this explanation, that Bhūcarī is definitely the vajra of speech and Pātālavāsinī that of body, come to contradict what is above and below? Because it is connected with "Pātālavāsinī," Bhūcarī is not the vajra of body, speech, and mind, since she is presented without a fixed assignment.

The goddesses of the intermediate directions are taught as having the nature of the four elements. "The vase of bodhicitta" refers to the passage beginning "Awakening": the nature of the water element is Śavarī. "Mount Meru" is the nature of earth, that is, Pukkasī. "The fire hearth" is purified heat, that is, Caṇḍālī. "The great victory banner" is the nature of wind, that is, Ḍombinī. The extensive teaching of the sequence of the maṇḍalas, too, expresses this same point, through this presentation of being urged by Śavarī and Pukkasī and acting with loving-kindness and compassion. "The vase of bodhicitta and Mount Meru" and "The lotus and the great banner" are the vajra, because of the seminal fluid.

"The source of the maṇḍalas" teaches an explanation of the maṇḍala comprised of the bodies of the deities. "Or abiding in the center of each eight": for each, these are the eights of the blessed principals of the eight deities, and the meaning is that one meditates on the supreme maṇḍala abiding in their center. Having first drawn the maṇḍala of Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara just as it is, in its center, too, is the maṇḍala of Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara made up of nine. In the eastern and other directions of the central maṇḍala are the maṇḍalas of Vairocana, Vajrasūrya, Padmanarteśvara, and Paramāśva, each made up of nine. Having considered it in this way, one draws the maṇḍala of whichever

one wishes to be the lord; its maṇḍala is the maṇḍala of that very one. In the eastern and other directions one should draw their maṇḍalas.

"Or as twenty-five" means that when these maṇḍalas are wanted with two tiers, one draws the maṇḍala with both tiers, and on its central tier is the central tier, made up of five, of that very one. In its eastern and other directions are the heart tiers of the others, each made up of five.

For the two that are other than the maṇḍala of twenty-five deities, there are others as well: the maṇḍala of Heruka made up of nine, and the maṇḍala of Nairātmyā, which is taught as made up of thirteen. For the two condensed maṇḍalas, it is taught that the gatekeepers of the maṇḍala are to be set out in the positions of the two maṇḍalas; this is the passage beginning "The gatekeepers." "Renowned as the elephant and so on" refers to the hand emblems of Heruka taught above.

"The element of space" is the source of phenomena, and its space is space itself. Its nature is the abode of supreme liberation. "The body pervaded by blood and semen" is merely illustrative. Because the impurities of the others arise as well, it is the element of faults. Likewise, because the formless realm has not arisen, that too arises. If, again, the arising of the three realms is set aside, then "on the earth, beneath the earth, and in the sky" here teaches the abodes. "Just as of sentient beings agitated by wind" is said in keeping with what is commonly known in the world; it is not what is known from the treatises.

The passage beginning "With a very lovely face," and "Fully endowed with the lotus flower," which means fully endowed with the lotus and with the flower, touch briefly on the secret empowerment. The passage beginning "Red lotus" teaches the wisdom-gnosis.

This completes the Explanatory Commentary on the Chapter of the Great King of Tantras Called the Noble Ḍākinī Vajrapañjara, composed by the great master Kṛṣṇapāda.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor, the venerable Gayādhara, and the Tibetan translator, the monk Shākya Yeshé.

Translator's Notes

• The first line of the homage is read as the author naming himself, Kṛṣṇa, humbly "far from wisdom." In the homage, 'dren skyo ba is read as 'dren skyob, "guide and protector," and dbang phyung as dbang phyug, "lord"; the master named there could not be identified, so his

name is translated by its meaning. The text often fuses the particle la with a neighboring syllable (sgral for sgra la, rol for ro la, skul for sku la); accordingly las spyod ma, both in the triad with Khecarī and Pātālavāsinī and in the verse on touch, is read as la sa spyod ma, Bhūcarī, the earth-going goddess. Here rigs drug means the six tantric families that the verse itself lists, not the six classes of beings. The maṇḍala of Mahendra is the earth disc, which with the water, fire and wind maṇḍalas forms the elemental base of the celestial palace. "One short of twenty" (nineteen) appears to count the eighteen elements plus their primordially unborn nature.

• Evident scribal slips were read as follows: phyi mdor as phyir mdor ("in order to ... in brief"), grub zhib as gru bzhi ("square"), and the doubled phrase "gnosis itself" was rendered once. In this piece bdag med pa is the doctrinal term "selflessness," which the commentary itself glosses as the selflessness of persons, not the goddess Nairātmyā. In the series father, son, and ma mo, ma mo is given as "mother goddess (mātṛkā)" following the house glossary, though it may simply mean "mother" here. The gatekeeper goddess skam pa ma could not be identified with confidence and is rendered by its literal sense, "the Dry One." The statement about the all-base consciousness of the container world, "one from another" (gcig las gcig), is obscure and is rendered literally.

• Evident scribal slips were read as follows: sgyu mchen po as sgyu ma chen po, "great illusion"; lhag pa'i ltar sgrub as lhag pa'i lha sgrub, "accomplishing one's own special deity"; ri ra ba as ri rab, "Mount Meru"; rlung gi ras bzhin as rlung gi rang bzhin, "the nature of wind"; g.yang mo as g.yung mo, the usual Tibetan for Ḍombinī, who completes the set of four with Śavarī, Pukkasī and Caṇḍālī; and 'phang ma as 'phar ma, "tier." The obscure ldeg par 'gyur is read as lding bar 'gyur, "will soar." "Five hundred thousand children" keeps byis pa as written; the phrase is obscure, and byis pa may be a slip for byas pa, "having done." Byams pa is taken as Maitreya because of the mention of Tuṣita and the bodhisattvas just before; it could also mean "loving-kindness." The gatekeeper goddess rdo rje sgo lcags ma could not be identified and is rendered literally as "Vajra Bolt." Rdza rnga ma, "Clay Drum," is given as Murajā, the drum goddess of the usual set of four music goddesses with Vaṃśā, Vīṇā and Mukundā. In the reply about Bhūcarī, rdo rje ma yin te is read as a negation; it could also be read "is the Vajrā of body, speech, and mind," which makes the same point, that her assignment is not fixed.

• Evident scribal slips were read as follows: bstan bcos kye grags pa with the genitive kyi, "known from the treatises," and nag po zhags in the colophon as nag po zhabs, Kṛṣṇapāda. The sentence on the formless realm, "because the formless realm has not arisen, that too arises," is obscure and is rendered literally. "The wisdom-gnosis" refers to the third empowerment, the wisdom-gnosis empowerment, which follows the secret empowerment just mentioned.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.